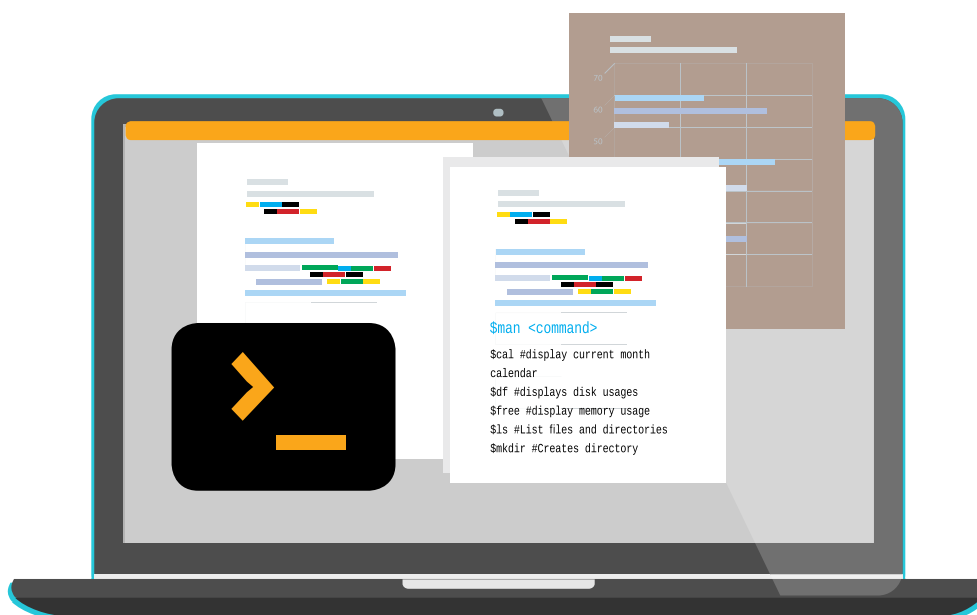


The Basic Concepts of Shell Scripting

If you want to automate regular tasks and make your life easier, using shell scripts is a good option. This article introduces you to the basic concepts that will help you to write efficient shell scripts.



A shell script is a computer program designed to be run by the UNIX shell, a command-line interpreter. The various dialects of shell scripts are considered to be scripting languages. Typical operations performed by shell scripts include file manipulation, program execution, and printing of text. A script that sets up the environment, runs the program, and does any necessary cleanup or logging, is called a wrapper.

Identification of shell prompt

You can identify whether the shell prompt on a Linux based computer is a normal or super user by looking at the symbols of the prompt in the terminal window. The '#' symbol is used for a super user and the '\$' symbol is used for a user with standard privileges.

Basic commands

The script comes with too many commands that can be executed on the terminal window to manage your computer. Details of

each command can be found in the manual included with the command. To view the manual, you need to run the command:

```
$man <command>
```

A few frequently used commands are:

```
$date #display current date and time
$cal #display current month calendar
$df #displays disk usages
$free #display memory usage
$ls #List files and directories
$mkdir #Creates directory
```

Each command comes with several options that can be used along with it. You can refer to the manual for more details. See Figure 1 for the output of:

```
$man date
```